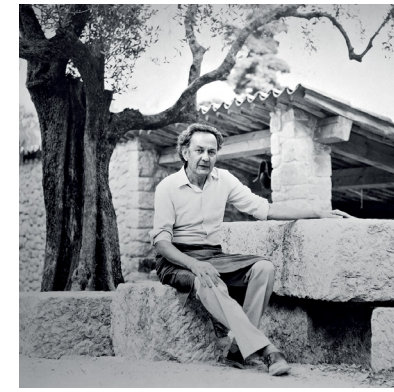
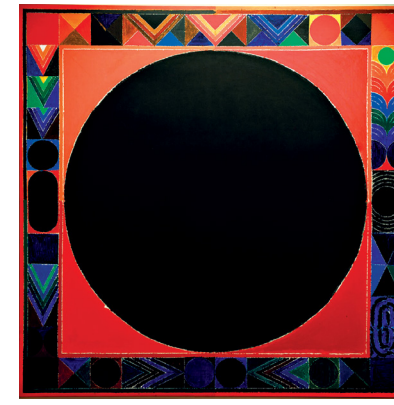








Artistic Journey (from left) 'Bahori Kadal', 'Italian Village', Raza at his Gorbio studio, (below right) 'Sansarii', (opposite) 'Germination'

EXHIBITION

THE MASTER of ARTS

USING JUST 50 WORKS, ***TRAVERSING SPACE*** TELLS US THE STORY OF HOW S.H. RAZA'S ART EVOLVED

This exhibition is readily digestible, containing just 50 works. But they are skilfully selected—by Roobina Karode of KNMA (Kiran Nadar Museum of Art)—to represent each successive phase of the artistic career of Sayed Haider Raza, and so offering a mini retrospective. Some of these phases appear superficially to mark drastic changes in approach. But the selection also brings out the recurring preoccupations that serve as connecting threads, making the whole look seamless.

In the 1940s, fresh out of art school in Nagpur, having moved to Bombay, Raza was an urban landscape painter, working mostly in gouache or watercolour on paper. The handling is loose but adept, so that forms seem rapidly but accurately drawn. The colouring is vibrant, almost Fauvist in works like 'Bombay from Malabar Hill' (1948). Following his introduction to Paris in 1950, he adds oils to his range of media, and the cityscapes become more geometric. Natural and fluid forms like trees and lawns are stripped away, often leaving parts of the page blank, so that he can focus on the complex and angular forms of architecture. What seems to interest him here is three-dimensional structure. It may surprise us, then, that at this time his more rural subjects—like his early, bright, impressionistic Kashmiri landscapes—veer towards abstraction. The effect of landscape is still strong, but the forms begin to dissipate, and sometimes we need a title, like 'La Plage' (1961), to tell us where we are. The connection, perhaps, is a concern not so much to *show* landscape as to make something new out of it—sometimes a mathematical model and sometimes an abstract pattern.



The selection of S.H. Raza's works also brings out the recurring preoccupations, making the whole look seamless

He continued for a while to switch between figurative and abstract, between French and Indian themes, between canvas and paper, and between large and small scales. The next apparent big break came around 1980, when he began to respond to miniature painting. His response was not to its scale, nor—despite his eclectic sense of the sacred—to its subject matter, but to its palette and its structure. He took the colours of Rajput painting, es-